Connect Google Drive

Let your helper read the documents you keep in Drive, alongside you.

Kind Walkthrough | Changed 2026-11-04 | For Anyone whose documents live in Drive

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TL;DR

1. **Many of us keep our real working documents in Google Drive.** Connect Drive to your helper and it can read and search them alongside you.
2. **The simple path:** your helper's built-in Drive connection, for reading and searching.
3. **The power path:** a Google Workspace command-line profile, for helpers that also edit documents. Use one profile per organization, so accounts never mix.

> ***Handing this to your AI helper?*** *Say: "Read CONNECT-GOOGLE-DRIVE.md and help me connect my Drive. Use the simple path, read-only."*

The simple path: built-in connections

ChatGPT

In ChatGPT, open the plugins (apps) list, choose **Google Drive**, and sign in with the Google account that holds your documents. Then: *"Find my retreat itinerary in Drive and summarise it."*

Claude (web and desktop)

Open **Settings** → **Connectors**, connect **Google Drive**, and sign in. Then ask Claude to search or read a document by name.

Codex and Claude Code

These helpers work best with documents that live **in the repository**. When a Drive document should shape a website, ask your chat helper to read it, then bring the agreed words into the repository's content files. That way the change rehearses like any other.

The power path: one Workspace profile per organization

For helpers that should **edit** Docs or Sheets, set up the Google Workspace CLI (`gws`) with a separate profile for each Google account:

1. **A Google Cloud project per account:** for example `thef-workspace` . Enable the Drive, Docs and Sheets APIs there.
2. **An OAuth client** (type *Desktop app*) in that project. Download its `client_secret.json` into the profile's own folder, such as `~/.config/gws-thef/` . Never put it in a repository.
3. **Add yourself as a test user** on the project's OAuth consent screen. Otherwise Google blocks the sign-in with *Error 403: access_denied*.
4. **Sign in under that profile:** `GOOGLE_WORKSPACE_CLI_CONFIG_DIR=~/.config/gws-thef gws auth login`
5. **Give it a short alias** so the account is always explicit, such as `alias gwsthef='GOOGLE_WORKSPACE_CLI_CONFIG_DIR=~/.config/gws-thef gws'` .

Each profile has its own project, its own client and its own token, so organizations never share credentials.

Good to know

- **Read is the default.** The built-in connections read and search; editing takes the power path, on purpose.
- **Private stays private.** A document being readable by your helper doesn't make it publishable. The never-publish rule still applies.
- **Shared drives:** your helper sees only what *your* account can see. Ask the drive's owner, not the helper, for wider access.

Suggest a change

Noticed something wrong, or know a better way? Open an issue or a pull request against `main`; the lab steward reads them, and a person with the role merges with a merge commit so your name stays on it. Not on GitHub? Tell any steward you know, or your helper, in your own words.

One of the walkthroughs in `my-template`. Icons: Phosphor duotone (MIT).